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Canada : Governor Newsom Signs Bills to Increase Financial Aid, Improve Integrity in College Admissions and Hold For-Profit Colleges Accountable

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Building on the states historic investment in two years of free community college and substantial state budget investments that allowed the University of California and the California State University to freeze tuition, Governor Gavin Newsom signed a series of bills into law today focused on affordability, transparency and integrity in higher education. The bills expand access to financial aid for students, strengthen integrity in college admissions and enhance oversight of for-profit colleges in California.

Higher education has the power to transform lives, and all hardworking young people in our state deserve a shot at it, said Governor Newsom. This package of bills strikes at the forces that keep the doors of opportunity closed to too many people in our state. Together, were improving affordability, transparency and integrity in higher education. I thank the Legislature for making this commitment to our students and our future.

Increasing Financial Aid

Just days after being sworn in, the Governor proposed that the California budget provide for two years of community college tuition-free for first-time, full-time students by expanding the California College Promise program. The Legislature approved the Governors proposal over the summer, and the Governor signed the legislation in June. The 2019-2020 state budget includes $42.6 million to support a second year of free tuition for approximately 33,000 students.

The budget also includes $41.8 million to increase the number of competitive Cal Grant scholarships and significantly increases funding for the University of California and California State University systems, facilitating tuition freezes and increased enrollment slots for the 2019-20 school year. Additionally, the budget includes $50 million for child savings accounts that aid families in managing future higher education expenses, and assists student parents through $96.7 million provided to support the living expenses of those with dependent children, and by establishing or increasing Cal Grant Access Awards, a two-generation approach that will help students complete their education and increase their future earning potential.

The bills signed into law today include:

AB 2 by Assemblymember Miguel Santiago (D-Los Angeles) expands access to the California College Promise Program by allowing students who are part of Disabled Students Programs and Services to qualify even if they are not enrolled in a full-time course load.

AB 943 by Assemblymember David Chiu (D-San Francisco) authorizes the use of funding from the CCC Student Equity and Achievement Program for emergency student financial assistance to help students overcome unforeseen financial challenges that would prevent them from completing their course of study.

AB 1278 by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino) addresses housing and food insecurity and mental health by requiring CSU, CCC and UC campuses to include information about public services and programs including CalFresh, housing resources and mental health services on their student web portals.

SB 150 by Senator Jim Beall (D-San Jose) relaxes the requirements and process for recipients of the Chafee Educational and Training Vouchers award, which provides financial aid to current and former foster youth enrolled in qualifying institutions of higher education.

SB 354 by Senator Maria Elena Durazo (D-Los Angeles) expands eligibility for the California DREAM loan program to students enrolled in professional or graduate degree programs.

Integrity in College Admissions

The Governor signed three bills into law today addressing the college admissions scandal that rocked some of Californias universities earlier this year.

AB 136 by Assemblywoman Sharon Quirk-Silva (D-Fullerton) prevents anyone found guilty in the admissions scandal from taking tax deductions for donations made to the charities involved.

AB 697 by Assemblymember Philip Ting (D-San Francisco) requires the CSU Trustees, UC Regents, and the appropriate governing bodies of each independent institution of higher education, to report to the Legislature, whether their respective institutions provide any form of preferential treatment in admissions to applicants on the basis of their relationships to donors or alumni of the institution.

AB 1383 by Assemblymember Kevin McCarty (D-Sacramento) strengthens the admission by exception system to require at least three campus administrators to approve admission for each applicant being considered for an exemption.

For-Profit College Accountability

To protect students against closures and poor outcomes at for-profit colleges, Governor Newsom signed three bills that increase accountability and transparency.

AB 1340 by Assemblymember David Chiu (D-San Francisco) will demonstrate whether for-profit institutions are effectively preparing students for the job market by requiring the Bureau for Private Postsecondary Education to calculate a debt-to-income ratio for both the for-profit institution and the programs they offer.

AB 1344 by Assemblymember Rebecca Bauer-Kahan (D-Orinda) increases state oversight of out-of-state institutions that enroll California students in online programs the largest share of which are for-profit colleges. The bill strengthens consumer protections by giving the Bureau for Private Postsecondary Education authority to place these institutions on a probationary status and revoke authorization to enroll California students if they do not comply.

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